ment to keep him out of Chhattisgarh. "Stories of my exit from Chhattisgarh are regularly put out by the ruling party [Congress] and are played up in the media. I am a loyal soldier of the party [BJP] and will serve it in whatever capacity I am asked to," Raman Singh, who is also the BJP's national vice-president, told INDIA TODAY, downplaying the rumours.

But how exactly is the BJP placed in Chhattisgarh if Raman Singh is marginalised? There are many within the state BJP who feel that he is still the party's best bet to take on Chief Minister Bhupesh Baghel. "Raman Singh is perhaps the only leader in the state who has a pan-Chhattisgarh appeal. Being in office for 15 years ensured that he had the time to cultivate a generation of leaders. It will not be easy to ignore him," a BJP state legislator maintains.

For the ruling Congress, too, he apparently remains the lone face of the Opposition. "Even after the BJP has appointed a new state president and leader of opposition, the CM's attacks are always directed towards Raman Singh. Similarly, Raman Singh is the only leader who takes on the CM," says political analyst Ashok Tomar. "There are no other BJP leaders in Chhattisgarh—be it from tribal or OBC communities—with that heft."

Before the assembly election, Chhattisgarh will witness a byelection in Bhanupratappur within six months. The tribal-dominated seat is a part of the Bastar region, where the BJP is eyeing electoral gains in 2023. With the Congress consistently winning all four byelections held in the state since 2018, the upcoming bypoll will be a litmus test for the BJP's new guard and is likely to set the tone for the big electoral battle ahead. ■

JAMMU & KASHMIR

THE UPSET APPLECART



ROTTEN IN TRANSIT
Labourers loading apple boxes on a truck at a *mandi* in Shopian

By Moazum Mohammad

A curious irony is growing in the apple orchards of rural Kashmir these day. In the daytime, you would be hard-pressed to find anyone outside their orchards. They are all hard at work, picking a bumper crop. The harvest this year, claim the growers and the horticulture department of Jammu and Kashmir, has broken all records. But the fruit of their labour does not seem to be reaching the villagers of the Valley. Multiple issues plague the Rs 10,000-crore horticulture sector, including disruptions in the supply chain, inflation, shortage of cold storages and labour, and import of Iranian apples. It scarcely bodes well for a sector that employs 700,000 families directly and another 3.5 million indirectly.

In south Kashmir's Shopian, known as the Apple Bowl of the Valley, Mushtaq Ahmad Malik is grappling with a double whammy—shortage of labour and transportation delay. The owner of orchards measuring 40 kanals in his village Pannu pays 10 labourers Rs 10,000 a day to pluck, sort and pack apples. His annual yield is 4,000 boxes of 17 kg each of two varieties of apple—juicy and crunchy Kullu and red delicious—from about 1,000 trees. This year, his harvest is expected to rise